

PHILIP P. ARNOLD, SANDRA BIGTREE, ADAM DJ BRETT

Syracuse University

CONCLUSION: DISMANTLING THE DOCTRINE OF CHRISTIAN DISCOVERY CULTIVATING RIGHT
RELATIONS

Abstract

This conclusion reaffirms the central thesis of the volume: the Doctrine of Christian Discovery (DoCD) is a persistent and pervasive system of domination, shaping legal, theological, and cultural structures that perpetuate Indigenous dispossession and white supremacy. Drawing upon scholarship and activism presented at the 2023 Syracuse University conference, the essays reveal how the DoCD is embedded in law, education, tourism, and national identity, sustaining the authority of settler colonialism. The contributors emphasize that true change requires more than legal reform; it demands metaphysical and cultural disobedience to the ideologies underpinning Christian empire and racial capitalism. Enacting justice calls for decolonial approaches—centering Indigenous cosmologies, fostering relationality, and transforming educational and public discourses. Highlighting both harm and healing, the volume advances pedagogical strategies that challenge erasure and settler innocence, urging a return to Indigenous land and knowledge. Grounded in the Haudenosaunee “Two Row Wampum” method and inspired by global Indigenous resistance, the conclusion calls for a comprehensive reimagining of law, theology, and society. Decolonization, it asserts, is ongoing work: requiring the restoration of land, the honoring of Indigenous law, and the cultivation of right relations.

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This volume closes in the same spirit that it opened: with an insistence that the Doctrine of Christian Discovery (DoCD) is not an artifact of the past but a living system of domination. Across its theological, legal, historical, and pedagogical dimensions, the DoCD continues to shape the material conditions of Indigenous dispossession, racial hierarchy, and ecological violence. As the contributors to this collection demonstrate, the DoCD is not only a series of 15th-century papal bulls or a set of U.S. Supreme Court rulings – it is embedded in the affective landscapes of tourism, the epistemologies of classrooms, the self-conception of settler democracies, and the spiritual justifications of empire. Even non-Christian traditions which have unreflexively absorbed the settler colonial mentality of eurochristian imperialism must come to terms with the DoCD's legacy (Tinker and Green 2023a; 2023b; 2023c; 2023d). This volume, grounded in the 2023 Syracuse University conference, brings together voices from across Indigenous nations, academic disciplines, and activist networks to name this enduring system and chart pathways toward its dismantling.

The essays by legal scholars such as Peter d'Errico, Steven Newcomb (Shawnee/Lenape), Robert J. Miller (Eastern Shawnee), Joseph Heath, and JoDe Goudy (Yakma Nation) expose how U.S. law rests on theological foundations of Christian superiority and white sovereignty. They demonstrate how the *Johnson v. M'Intosh* decision of 1823, and its subsequent reaffirmations in cases like *City of Sherrill v. Oneida Indian Nation* (2005), continue to block Indigenous land claims and deny Native sovereignty. Legal critiques throughout the volume argue that undoing these systems will require more than legal reform – it will demand metaphysical disobedience to the premises of Christian empire and racial capitalism. These writers do not merely seek to reinterpret existing law; they seek to dismantle it, to uproot the fictions of sovereignty and property that have made empire seem inevitable and just.

Yet, as scholars like Sarah Nahar, Wendy Felese, Maeve Callan, and Pranay Somayajula emphasize, this is not only a legal struggle – it is also a theological and cultural one. The religious underpinnings of the Doctrine of Discovery continue to inform national identity, public memory, and the unspoken assumptions of settler colonial worldviews. From the enduring myths of “Chosen People and Promised Land” to the racialized constructions of Hindu nationalism, the essays demonstrate how religious narratives authorize domination while hiding behind secular legal language. In response, contributors call for decolonial theologies rooted in Indigenous cosmologies, feminist critiques, and land-based spiritualities that refuse the logic of conquest and instead affirm relationality, reciprocity, and responsibility.

This volume also attends pedagogy and public discourse as sites of both harm and healing. The chapters by Renee Berry, Danielle Nagle, Michael Chaness, Roberta Hurtado, Ritu Radhakrishnan, and Celinet Duran Jimenez call for educators to resist the affective and epistemic violence that maintains settler innocence. Whether confronting the erasure of Haudenosaunee dispossession in Erie Canal heritage or reimagining classrooms as spaces of Indigenous resurgence and critical inquiry, these essays challenge readers to examine how curricula, tourism, and commemorations shape what is remembered – and what is denied. They point to the importance of embodiment, emotion, and land-based knowledge as tools for

disrupting the normalization of white supremacy and Christian imperialism in daily life and institutional systems.

Ultimately, this volume is not an end but an invitation: to rupture silence, recover forgotten voices, challenge Christian hegemony, resist religious nationalism, and to honor Indigenous law and land, and to realign our work – whether legal, spiritual, educational, or communal – toward justice. It also illustrates the significance of working cross-culturally in a way that coordinates scholarly and Indigenous perspectives. In his book *The Urgency of Indigenous Values* (SU Press, 2023) Philip Arnold refers to this as the “Two Row Wampum” method that has informed our work now and into the future. Inspired by the Haudenosaunee principles of peace, power, and righteousness, and grounded in the legacy of resistance from Turtle Island to the Global South, the contributors here urge us to act with clarity and humility. Rescinding the papal bulls is not enough. We must remake our laws, our theologies, our institutions, and our imaginations. As many authors remind us, the future depends not on reforming settler systems but on returning land, repairing relationships, and remembering older, deeper ways of being in right relation with the land and with one another. This is the work of decolonization. This is the work that remains.